



THE GOOD LIFE

TRENDS

A CUP OF COUTURE Chai

AS WELLNESS TRENDS AND YOUNGER CONSUMERS RESHAPE TASTES, INDIA'S EVERYDAY TEA RITUAL IS EVOLVING INTO A LUXURY EXPERIENCE

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

“I T'S ALWAYS tea-time,” said the Mad Hatter in *Alice in Wonderland*. He

could just as well be talking about Indians who love their *chai* so much that they can have it any time of the day. For us, tea has long been a daily ritual, poured into little cutting chai glass tumblers at roadside stalls, or simmered with milk and spices in millions of homes. But a quieter shift is unfolding at the higher end of the market. Tea is being repositioned not simply as a comforting beverage but as a luxury experience, driven by younger consumers and a growing awareness of its health benefits.

The change is visible in boutique tea rooms, curated online stores and luxury hotel menus where teas are described with the same care once reserved for fine wines. Single-origin leaves, artisanal blends, rare harvests

and everything from *Ashwagandha* to Chamomile is finding an expanding audience among young urban consumers who are as interested in wellness as they are in flavour.

According to the India Premium Tea Market Report and Forecast 2025–34 by Research and Markets, the country's premium tea market reached 1.15 million tonnes in 2024 and is expected to grow at a CAGR of 4.2%, reaching 1.74 million tonnes by 2034. Rising disposable incomes, urbanisation and health-conscious lifestyles are pushing consumers toward higher-quality, specialty teas, it says. Exports are also strengthening: India's tea shipments rose 9.92% in 2024, reaching

254.67 million kilograms, indicating strong international demand.

But the most notable development is taking place closer home. “Historically, the demand for high-end Darjeeling teas has been driven by international markets such as Japan, Germany and the United States,” says Rudra Chatterjee, managing director of Luxmi Tea Co Private Ltd, that owns the Makaibari tea estate. “However, in the last few years, we have seen a noticeable shift in India as well. Indian consumers are becoming more curious”

That curiosity is changing how luxury tea itself is defined. For decades, high-end tea was